Autism & Me

An Autism & Me product

Six Steps

Lesson Cards for Learners and Teachers

A step only counts when it lands.

1	2	3	4	5	6
START	TAKE IT IN	MAKE SENSE	HAVE A GO	SHOW IT	CHECK & CLOSE

Six cards for the learner. Six matching cards for the teacher. Works in any subject, with any teacher.

Built on the three principles of Universal Design for Learning (CAST UDL Guidelines 3.0): engagement, representation, and action & expression.

Learner's name: _____

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How the tool works

Every lesson has six steps. Each step has two cards: one for the learner, one for the teacher. The cards are numbered and named the same, so both people are always looking at the same step.

The one rule

A teacher step is DONE only when the learner has marked YES on their card for that step.

The teacher doing the step is not the same as the step working. If the prompt goes out and the learner does not respond — or responds NOT YET or I NEED… — the step has not landed yet. The teacher tries once more, a different way. After two tries, the teacher notes it and keeps the lesson moving. What is noted becomes the evidence for changing the lesson design.

Why it is built this way

- It removes ambiguity. "Did you explain the goal?" and "Did the learner get the goal?" are different questions. The tool only accepts the second one as proof.
- It puts the learner in charge of the evidence. The card is theirs. They decide how they answer — a tick, a point, holding the card up, or saying it. Nobody marks it for them.
- It is neuroaffirming and barrier-focused. When a step doesn't land, the next move is to change the way the step is delivered — not to change the learner. The retry options on each teacher card are all changes to the environment.
- It works in any subject, with any teacher, in a 40-minute class. The six steps are the shape of every lesson, from Maths to Home Economics.
- It produces a pattern. After a week the Weekly Overview shows which steps land and which don't, subject by subject. That is exactly the information a school needs to plan support, and it is written in the learner's own responses.

The six steps and the UDL principles behind them

Step	The learner's question	UDL principle
1 START	Do I know what this lesson is about, and what I have to do?	Engagement — a clear goal, welcoming interests; Representation — the goal is visible, not only spoken.
2 TAKE IT IN	Was the new information given to me in more than one way — not just spoken?	Representation — perception: the same information offered through more than one sense and format.
3 MAKE SENSE	Do I know what the key words mean, and how this connects to what I already know?	Representation — language and symbols; building knowledge: key vocabulary defined, links to prior learning made explicit.
4 HAVE A GO	Do I know exactly what to do first, how long I have, and can I do it in a way that suits me?	Action & Expression — physical action and scaffolded practice; Engagement — sustaining effort: clear steps, real choices, a known time limit.

Step	The learner's question	UDL principle
5 SHOW IT	Can I show what I learned in a way that suits me — say it, write it, draw it, type it, point to it, or make it?	Action & Expression — expression and communication: multiple ways to demonstrate learning, all treated as valid.
6 CHECK & CLOSE	Do I know one thing I learned, what the homework is (if any), and how this lesson went for me?	Engagement — self-regulation and reflection; Action & Expression — executive function: the lesson ends with a recap, a written next step and a check-in.

Steps 1–3 are mostly about what reaches the learner (engagement and representation). Steps 4–6 are mostly about what the learner can do with it and how the lesson ends (action & expression, and engagement again). Every step includes a genuine choice, because choice is what turns a delivered lesson into an accessible one.

For the learner — how to use your cards

These six cards are yours. They are the same in every class, with every teacher. You don't have to write anything unless you want to.

1. Keep your six cards (or one Lesson Strip) on your desk in every class.
2. The teacher will say a prompt for each step — like "The goal today is ___. Have you got it?"
3. You answer on your card: tick YES, NOT YET, or I NEED… — or point to it, or hold the card up, or say it. Any of those counts.
4. If you mark NOT YET or I NEED…, the teacher tries again a different way. That is the deal. It is their job to find the way that works, not yours.
5. You can also use the "Things I can say or point to" on each card at any time, without waiting for the prompt.
6. At the end, fill in the bottom of the Lesson Strip: how the lesson was (OK / Hard / Good), one thing you learned, and the homework.

Three things that are always true

- Nobody marks your card except you.
- NOT YET is a normal answer. It is not a bad answer.
- If a step never lands in one subject, that is a problem with the lesson, not with you. Show the strips to someone who can help change it — a parent, guardian, tutor or year head.

Part 1 — The learner's six cards

Print one per page (or two per A4 sheet as A5 cards). Laminate; use a dry-wipe marker.

1 MY CARD START

I know what we are doing and why.

THE QUESTION

Do I know what this lesson is about, and what I have to do?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"What is the goal today?"
"Can you write the goal on the board?"
"Why does this matter?"

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

2 MY CARD TAKE IT IN

I got the information in a way that works for me.

THE QUESTION

Was the new information given to me in more than one way — not just spoken?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"Can I have that written down?"
"Can I have a copy?"
"Can you show me, not just tell me?"

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

3 MY CARD MAKE SENSE

I understand the key words and how this fits with what I know.

THE QUESTION

Do I know what the key words mean, and how this connects to what I already know?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"What does ___ mean?"
"Can you give me an example?"
"How does this connect to last time?"

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

4 MY CARD HAVE A GO

I know exactly what to do first, and I can do it my way.

THE QUESTION

Do I know exactly what to do first, how long I have, and can I do it in a way that suits me?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"What is step 1?"
"Can I type / draw / talk it instead?"
"How long do we have?"
"Can you show me one first?"

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

5 MY CARD SHOW IT

I can show what I have learned in a way I choose.

THE QUESTION

Can I show what I learned in a way that suits me — say it, write it, draw it, type it, point to it, or make it?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"Can I show you a different way?"
"Can I point / say / draw it instead?"
"Can I show you next class?"

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

6 MY CARD CHECK & CLOSE

I know what I learned, what happens next, and how it went.

THE QUESTION

Do I know one thing I learned, what the homework is (if any), and how this lesson went for me?

MY ANSWER (tick one, point, or say it)

☐ **YES**
I've got it. This step is done.

☐ **NOT YET**
Try it again a different way.

☐ **I NEED…**
Tick what would help:

- ☐ it another way
- ☐ it written down
- ☐ an example
- ☐ more time
- ☐ a break
- ☐ to do it my way

THINGS I CAN SAY OR POINT TO

"What was the main thing today?"
"Can you write the homework down?"
"That lesson was hard for me."

My card. My answer.

This step is only done when I mark YES. If I have not marked it, the step is not finished — and that is not my fault. The teacher tries again a different way.

My Lesson Strip

One strip per class. Tick as the lesson goes. Keep it on the desk where the teacher can see it — or hold it up.

Subject	Teacher	Date

	Step	YES	NOT YET	I NEED…	What helped / what I needed
1	**START** I know what we are doing and why.				
2	**TAKE IT IN** I got the information in a way that works for me.				
3	**MAKE SENSE** I understand the key words and how this fits with what I know.				
4	**HAVE A GO** I know exactly what to do first, and I can do it my way.				
5	**SHOW IT** I can show what I have learned in a way I choose.				
6	**CHECK & CLOSE** I know what I learned, what happens next, and how it went.				

How was this lesson?	One thing I learned
OK ☐ Hard ☐ Good ☐	

Homework (written by the teacher, or by me while the teacher checks)

For teachers — how to use your cards

Thank you for using these. They take about 90 seconds of a lesson in total and they are built on Universal Design for Learning, so everything on them is good practice for the whole class — the learner's card is simply the check that it worked.

The routine

1. Before the lesson, glance at the six teacher cards (two minutes). Most of what they ask is already in a well-planned lesson: a written goal, more than one mode, key words, numbered steps, a choice of how to show learning, a written recap and homework.
2. At each step, say the prompt on the card (or your own words with the same meaning) and look at the learner's card.
3. YES marked = landed. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and carry on.
4. Anything else = not landed yet. Pick one option from "If not landed", then prompt again. Two tries maximum, then note it and keep the lesson moving.
5. At the end of the lesson, complete your Lesson Strip. It takes a minute and it is the record that matters.

What to expect

- The learner answers their card their own way — tick, point, hold it up, or say it. Please accept whichever they use; don't ask them to switch to a different one.
- Don't mark their card for them, and don't ask them to "just tick yes" so the lesson can move on. A NOT YET that is recorded honestly is worth far more than a YES that isn't true.
- "I did my part" and "Landed" are separate columns on purpose. Both matter. If you do your part and it does not land, that is useful information, and it is not a judgement on your teaching.
- Most retry options (a printed copy, a worked example, a starter sentence, a written homework line) help other students too. Feel free to use them for the whole class.

Two tries, then move on

Lessons have to keep going, and no learner wants to be the reason a class stalls. Two attempts at a step is the limit. A step that does not land after two tries is recorded and reviewed at the weekly check-in — that is where the fix is designed, not in the middle of the lesson.

Part 2 — The teacher's six cards

One card per step. Each card ends by pointing at the learner's card of the same number.

1 TEACHER CARD START

I know what we are doing and why.

UDL: Engagement — a clear goal, welcoming interests; Representation — the goal is visible, not only spoken.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

The learner knows the goal of the lesson and what they will do. Not the topic name — the goal.

DO

1. Say the goal in one plain sentence: "By the end of today you will be able to ___."
2. Write that sentence on the board (or slide) and leave it there for the whole lesson.
3. Link it in one line to something the learner already knows, did last lesson, or cares about.

SAY — the prompt

"The goal today is ___. That's written up there. Have you got it? Mark your card."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 1

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 1. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Shrink the goal to three words and write those.
- Show a finished example of what the lesson produces.
- Ask the learner to say the goal back in their own words — then use their words.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

2 TEACHER CARD TAKE IT IN

I got the information in a way that works for me.

UDL: Representation — perception: the same information offered through more than one sense and format.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

New information reaches the learner through at least two channels (spoken + written, spoken + shown, written + diagram). Speech on its own is not enough.

DO

1. Present anything new in at least two ways: say it and show it, or say it and give it on paper.
2. Give the learner a copy they can keep (handout, photo of the board, shared file).
3. Chunk it: one idea at a time, pause, then the next.

SAY — the prompt

"Here it is spoken, and here it is written / shown as well. Is that a version you can use? Mark your card."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 2

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 2. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Hand over a printed or digital copy right now.
- Slow down and give it in smaller pieces.
- Add a picture, diagram, or short example.
- Let the learner photograph the board or record the explanation.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

3 TEACHER CARD MAKE SENSE

I understand the key words and how this fits with what I know.

UDL: Representation — language and symbols; building knowledge: key vocabulary defined, links to prior learning made explicit.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

The learner can understand the key vocabulary and can see how today's content connects to something already known.

DO

1. Name the three key words for the lesson and define each one in plain language, written up.
2. Give one concrete example for each key word.
3. Say out loud how today connects to the last lesson or to everyday life: "This is like ___."

SAY — the prompt

"The three key words are ___, ___ and ___ — they're up here with what they mean. Which one, if any, do you want again? Mark your card."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 3

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 3. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Add a picture or a physical example for the word that hasn't landed.
- Give a one-line summary: "All you need for now is ___."
- Use a comparison to something the learner already understands.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

4 TEACHER CARD HAVE A GO

I know exactly what to do first, and I can do it my way.

UDL: Action & Expression — physical action and scaffolded practice; Engagement — sustaining effort: clear steps, real choices, a known time limit.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

The learner can begin the task without guessing: the first step is stated, the steps are numbered, the time is known, and there is a genuine choice of method.

DO

1. Break the task into numbered steps and write them up. Point to step 1.
2. Offer at least two ways to do it (write / type / draw / say / build / use a template).
3. State the time available and where to look if stuck.

SAY — the prompt

"Step 1 is ___. You have ___ minutes. Which way do you want to do it? Mark your card, then start."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 4

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 4. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Model step 1 yourself, out loud, then hand it over.
- Give a starter (a sentence opener, a template, a worked example to copy from).
- Reduce to one step only: "Just do this, then come back to me."
- Pair with a classmate for the first step.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

5 TEACHER CARD SHOW IT

I can show what I have learned in a way I choose.

UDL: Action & Expression — expression and communication: multiple ways to demonstrate learning, all treated as valid.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

The learner has shown what they learned in a format they chose, and it was accepted as real evidence.

DO

1. Offer at least two ways to show learning before asking for it.
2. Accept any of them as evidence — no format is worth more than another.
3. Give one line of feedback that names what was right, then one next step.

SAY — the prompt

"Show me what you've got — say it, write it, draw it, type it, or point to it. Mark your card when you've shown me."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 5

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 5. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Switch to multiple choice or yes / no questions.
- Ask the learner to point to the answer in their notes or on the board.
- Accept a partial answer and name the part that is correct.
- Agree that they will show it at the start of next class instead.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

6 TEACHER CARD CHECK & CLOSE

I know what I learned, what happens next, and how it went.

UDL: Engagement — self-regulation and reflection; Action & Expression — executive function: the lesson ends with a recap, a written next step and a check-in.

WHAT THIS STEP MEANS

The learner leaves knowing one thing they learned, exactly what (if anything) is due, and has had a chance to say how the lesson went.

DO

1. Recap in one sentence: "Today you learned ___."
2. Write the homework (or "No homework") on the board and in the journal or app. Never speech-only.
3. Ask how the lesson went: OK / Hard / Good. Take the answer seriously.

SAY — the prompt

"One thing you learned today? Homework is ___ — it's written here. How was that lesson: OK, hard, or good? Mark your card."

THEN LOOK AT THE LEARNER'S CARD 6

LANDED = The learner has marked YES on their Card 6. Tick "Landed" on your Lesson Strip and move on.

NOT LANDED = anything else: NOT YET, I NEED…, blank, or no response. The step is not done yet.

Your part being complete does not make the step complete. Only the learner's card does.

IF NOT LANDED — try ONE of these, then prompt again

- Say the one thing yourself and write it — then ask the learner to tick it.
- Put the homework on paper or in the app before the learner leaves the room.
- If it was Hard: agree one thing that will be different next lesson, and write it down.

Two tries, then note it on the Lesson Strip and keep the lesson moving. A step that does not land twice is information about the lesson design, not about the learner.

Teacher Lesson Strip

One strip per lesson. "I did my part" is your action. "Landed" is the learner's card — you may only tick it if they have marked YES. The two columns are deliberately separate.

Subject	Lesson goal (one sentence)	Date

	Step	I did my part	Landed (learner marked YES)	If not: what I tried	Landed after retry
1	START				
2	TAKE IT IN				
3	MAKE SENSE				
4	HAVE A GO				
5	SHOW IT				
6	CHECK & CLOSE				

Steps that did not land after two tries — what I will change next lesson

Weekly Overview — where do the steps land?

At the end of the week, copy the Lesson Strips into this grid. Write the number of lessons where the step LANDED over the number of lessons that week (for example 3/4). Blank cells and low fractions show where the lesson design needs to change — by subject and by step.

Week beginning: _____

Subject	1 START	2 TAKE IT IN	3 MAKE SENSE	4 HAVE A GO	5 SHOW IT	6 CHECK & CLOSE

Steps that land almost everywhere	Steps that rarely land — and in which subjects

What we will ask for (the one change per subject that would make the biggest difference)

Template — note for a learner's subject teachers

For a parent, guardian, SEN coordinator or tutor to adapt and send with the cards. Written to be read in under a minute.

Dear _____,

_____ is using a simple six-step card system in all their classes this term. Each step matches a normal part of a lesson (goal, new information, key words, the task, showing learning, the close). For each step there is a one-line prompt for you and a card for the learner to answer on — YES, NOT YET, or I NEED…

The only rule is that a step counts as done when they mark YES. If they don't, the card gives you a couple of quick options to try, and after two tries you just note it and carry on. Nothing on the cards is extra work beyond good lesson practice; the card is the check that it reached them.

Enclosed: your six teacher cards, a Teacher Lesson Strip to fill in each lesson, and a copy of the learner's cards so you can see exactly what they see. I'd be grateful if you could return the strips at the end of each week — we'll use them to see which steps land in which subjects, and to work out with you what would help where they don't.

Thank you — this will make a real difference.

_____

Design notes

Universal Design and UDL alignment

Principle	How the tool applies it
Equitable use	Every card has the same structure; the answer can be given by ticking, pointing, holding up or speaking. No format is privileged.
Simple and intuitive	One question per card. Three answers. Same six steps in every subject with every teacher.
Perceptible information	Number, name, and colour band together on every card — meaning is never carried by colour alone. Large sans-serif type (12–20 pt on cards).
Tolerance for error	NOT YET is a normal, expected answer. Two tries are built in. Nothing is marked as a fail.
Low physical effort	No writing required. A tick or a point is enough.
UDL — Engagement	Steps 1, 4 and 6: a clear goal, real choices in the task, and a close that asks how it went.
UDL — Representation	Steps 2 and 3: two modes minimum, key words defined, connections to prior knowledge made explicit.
UDL — Action & Expression	Steps 4 and 5: numbered steps, choice of method, choice of how to show learning.

Accessibility check (NeuroInclusive Design Lens)

Dimension	Status	Note / action
Sensory	Met	Plain layout, no clutter, high contrast. Print on matt card; laminate with a matt pouch to avoid glare.
Communication	Met	Every answer mode is accepted. Script lines on each card give the learner ready-made words.
Executive functioning	Met	Six fixed steps, always in the same order; the teacher prompt cues each one, so the learner does not have to remember to check in.
Cognitive	Met	One question per card, plain language, no jargon on the learner cards. UDL terms appear only on teacher cards.
Emotional safety	Partly met — to verify with the learner	NOT YET is framed as normal and the retry is the teacher's job. Verify with the learner that holding a card up in class feels OK; if not, keep it flat on the desk with the teacher glancing, or use a small desk-top version.
Physical	Met	Tick or point only; dry-wipe on laminated cards, or a paper strip per class.

Before first use — check with the learner

- Read the six card names and questions with the learner. Let them rename any step in their own words (the teacher cards should then use their wording).
- Ask how they want to answer in class: tick, point, hold up, or say. Tell their teachers which they have chosen — and that they may change their mind.
- Agree whether the cards are a personal tool or whether the whole class uses the Lesson Strip (a universal-design option that draws no attention to any one learner).
- Decide the format: six laminated A5 cards on a ring, or one A4 Lesson Strip per class. Many learners prefer the strip after the first week.

Areas to validate

- Does "two tries then move on" feel like the right limit in practice? Adjust after the first fortnight.
- Do the retry options on each teacher card match what actually helps this learner? Replace any that don't with their own suggestions.
- Does the Weekly Overview show a pattern after three weeks? If yes, that pattern is the agenda for the next meeting with the school.

Evidence status

The tool is built on CAST UDL Guidelines 3.0 and the seven principles of Universal Design (established frameworks). The specific six-step lesson shape and the "landed only when the learner marks it" rule are a practice design — sound in principle, to be validated in use with each learner and their teachers. No statistics or study findings are claimed.